Digging near utility lines.

Care around hot water, water, power and telecoms

VERSION	APPROVED	OWNER	WEB
1.0	27 October 2026	Managing director	pblondal.is/en/policies/groftur-naerri-veitulognum/

Digging near utility lines is among the highest-risk tasks for a groundwork contractor. Damage can cause serious burns, electric shock, flooding, loss of service and costly damage. P. Blöndal ehf. bases its methods on confirmed information about pipes and cables, cooperation with their owners and careful hand digging where needed. Each utility's own rules and the instructions of supervising authorities take precedence.

Preparation before digging

The latest maps, drawings and information are obtained from all relevant utility owners; a single map service does not necessarily show every line. Veitur, the Reykjavík utility company, specifically points out that the location of older lines may be inaccurate and that warning tape is not always present. If lines may be within the work area, their position is confirmed, by scanning where appropriate, and the method agreed before machine digging begins. For each job, instructions are obtained from the relevant utility and its latest procedures are followed.

Working near pipes and cables

When markings, a sand layer or other signs indicate pipes or cables, slow down and locate them using suitably careful methods. In areas where Veitur's instructions apply, a toothless bucket must be used near lines and hand digging done according to the guidelines. The bucket must be kept away from lines, and they must be protected from loads, impacts and damage to their casing. Special measures may be needed for an exposed pipe or cable in a trench.

High voltage and sensitive installations

When high-voltage cables are nearby, the operator must be consulted specifically, and the disconnection or other protective measures they decide on must be requested. The colour of the insulation or an estimated depth is never taken as confirmation that a cable is dead. Heating, water or sewer pipes must not be left hanging without an appropriate approved solution. Protection against collapse around pipes and cables is also essential.

Damage and completion

If damage occurs or is suspected, work is stopped and the area made safe; no unsafe repair is attempted. The owner of the line is contacted immediately, and the emergency services if there is imminent danger. For Veitur, their emergency number is used according to their published guidelines. Before a trench is closed,

the appropriate protective layers, warning tape, surveying and approved finishing are ensured.

Responsibility and review

The managing director is responsible for this document and for making sure its content is presented to everyone working on the company's behalf. It is reviewed when there are significant changes to the work, equipment or rules, after incidents, and otherwise regularly in line with the scale of the business.